

THE HAND'S MOVE
Victorious Congress candidate Byron Biswas; inset, Mamata Banerjee, who termed the Congress-Left understanding 'immoral'

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CONG-LEFT-MAMATA

LEFT'S HAND IN ALLIANCES

By Romita Datta

The results might have been different but for the alliance of the Left parties and Congress for the Tripura assembly polls and the byelections for the Sagardighi assembly seat in West Bengal's Murshidabad district. It surely raised the hackles of their main electoral opponents, the BJP and the Trinamool Congress. PM Narendra Modi, on the final day of campaigning in Tripura, warned voters that "old players of misgovernance have joined hands...even a single vote for them will take Tripura backwards". Bitter rivals during the 25-year Left rule in Tripura, the alliance did initially leave the arriviste BJP disconcerted, especially since its main agenda was to split the anti-BJP/ anti-incumbency votes. In the event, the BJP need not have worried: it won a majority on its own, winning 32 seats. Equally interesting was what happened at the other end: the Congress improved its tally from zero in 2018 to three and its vote share from 1.8 per cent to 8.6 per cent; the CPI(M), on the other hand, dipped from 16 to 11 seats, its vote share nearly halving to 24.6 per cent from 42 per cent. Pro-Left sceptics of the alliance were quick to conclude that the Congress benefited at the expense of the Left.

ANGERED AT THE SAGARDIGHI LOSS, MAMATA ANNOUNCED TMC WOULD FIGHT THE 2024 POLLS ALONE

If Modi had spelt out an anticipatory warning, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee's choleric outburst came after the TMC's shock defeat to the Congress in Sagardighi. There, the Left-backed candidate Byron Biswas defeated TMC's Debashish Banerjee by over 22,000 votes. It was particularly galling for the TMC as it had won the seat in the 2021 assembly polls by over 50,000 votes. The Congress vote share increased from 19.4 per cent to 47.3 per cent; that of the TMC fell to 35 per cent from 51 per cent. An irate Mamata attributed the loss to an "immoral alliance" between the Left and Congress, and accused them and the BJP of having a "give and take" relationship. The TMC, she added in a fit of pique, would fight the 2024 parliamentary polls alone. Observers say a massive swing of the Muslim vote away from the TMC—63 per cent of Sagardighi's population is Muslim—led to the upset.

The two contradictory results reopened an old question in a new